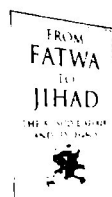


Satanic Temptations

Two books explain why the flames that burnt Salman Rushdie's novel continue to rage even two decades after the fatwa

| By S. Prasannarajan |



FROM FATWA TO JIHAD: THE RUSHDIE AFFAIR AND ITS LEGACY
by KENAN MALIK
Atlantic Books
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Twenty years ago, it was a book that threatened the Book. The book was written by a novelist who reduced the distance between memory and history. It was his fourth novel. The first, *Grimus*, makes him "hide behind the sofa when somebody starts reading it". The second, *Midnight's Children*, made him the boldest of his generation in English fiction. An epic exuding such subversive energy, and written in the accented patois of the displaced, the novel changed the very notion of storytelling in a language that traditionally defies the art of exaggeration. It made the novelist the most original chronicler of an India that was a "crowd", a "multitude"—and an idea ravaged by the politics of paranoia. It won the Booker, and it

would win the Booker of Bookers. His next book, *Shame*, turned the lost part of the subcontinent into a fable. Then happened the book that changed everything—everything that we thought was sacred. The writer, the writing, faith and God. *The Satanic Verses*, a novel more burnt than read, and whose literary evaluators ranged from mullahs to politicians, made Rushdie the most famous writer. On Valentine's Day two decades ago, Rushdie's novel became the singular enemy of the Great Islamic Revolution of Iran. As the novel about transmigrations and metamorphosis, about loss of faith and death, burnt in a bonfire of hate from Bradford to Islamabad, the blasphemer-novelist lost his world. As Kenan Malik writes in *From Fatwa to Jihad*, "The Rushdie affair was the moment at which a new Islam dramatically announced itself as a major political issue in Western society."

Rushdie may have regained his freedom and gone on to write some fabulous stories, but the flame that enveloped *The Satanic Verses* has gone far beyond Bradford. As Malik argues, Islam's sanguineous resentment has come a long way from the burning book to the burning towers to the burning bus to, well, the burning hotel. Like Rushdie, Malik, a writer and broadcaster, was born in India and brought up in Britain. His book is not about Rushdie but the politics of faith and fear in the aftermath of the fatwa. The politics, we Indians need not be reminded, could be desperate and dirty. We were the first to ban the book, and we were so eager to appease the likes of Syed Shahabuddin, who found the very title of the book "suggestively derogatory", and who too had not read the book ("I do not have to wade through a filthy drain to know what filth is.") Kenan's project, though, is more ambitious. It traces the trajectory of Islamist rage from war against imagination to war against civilisation—from fatwa to jihad. And his book shows how the combined force of multiculturalism and Western self-loathing has influenced the



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